

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

WEDNESDAY, APRIL 30, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

‘I expect this to be a tough job’

Chicago’s new US attorney balances office’s tradition with new directives from DC

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Chicago’s newly appointed U.S. attorney, Andrew Boutros, said Tuesday he’s committed to balancing the storied office’s traditional areas of focus such as public corruption with new policy directives coming from the Trump administration, from immigration to narcotics trafficking by international cartels.

In his first interview since assuming the powerful law enforcement post three weeks

ago, however, Boutros said he’ll be doing it with less manpower than in recent years, as there are now fewer than 100 federal criminal prosecutors and a hiring freeze mandated by the president that has no end in sight.

“I didn’t take this job because I thought it would be easy,” Boutros told a group of reporters who cover the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse. “I took this job knowing full well that there are tremendous pressures and expectations put on being U.S. attorney. ... I expect this to be a tough job. But I believe and

continue to believe that I am the right person for this job, and I will work tirelessly to carry out the mandate to the best of my ability.”

Boutros, a veteran Chicago lawyer and former federal prosecutor here, was sworn in April 7 as the 42nd U.S. attorney for the Northern District of Illinois, leading an office of about 130 criminal and civil attorneys and dozens more support employees that has long been recognized as one of the busiest and most prominent in the country.

But he’s taken the reins during a period of declining productivity for the office that began with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. And

Turn to Boutros, Page 7



U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros meets with the media at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on Tuesday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Battalion Chief Scott Shawaluk hugs Kristen Meyer, wife of Capt. David Meyer, during the funeral for the fire captain Tuesday at St. John Brebeuf Church in Niles. Shawaluk is a close friend and neighbor. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

HUNDREDS HONOR FIRE CAPTAIN AT FUNERAL

Meyer, a nearly 30-year veteran, remembered for bravery and selflessness

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

While the world watched in horror as the Twin Towers collapsed on Sept. 11, 2001, Chicago firefighter David Meyer packed up his gear and drove to the scene of the deadly terror attacks.

No one invited or ordered him to do so. But for days, Meyer stayed in New York, digging and searching for victims buried under the rubble.

The fire captain and father of four was remembered for always embodying this kind of bravery and selflessness during his funeral service Tuesday at St. John Brebeuf Church in Niles. The nearly 30-year veteran firefighter died last week after battling a suspicious garage fire in the Austin neighborhood.

“God put him on this earth so he could do God’s very work. And he did it well and he lived it fully,” said the Rev. Thomas Mulcrone, former chaplain for the Chicago Fire Department, during the eulogy. “There is a time to live and a time to die.



Chicago Fire Department Capt. David Meyer died after being critically injured in a garage fire in the city’s Austin neighborhood on April 23. **CHICAGO FIRE DEPARTMENT**

We can’t make sense today of the latter. But we can honor Dave, if we abide by the former.”

Hundreds of firefighters mourned their fallen colleague at the service, some filling the pews of the church, others standing outside, shoulder to shoulder, in solemn silence. A funeral procession of multiple fire engines, one adorned with wreaths of flowers and funeral sprays, passed under a large American flag suspended by two fire truck ladders that formed an arch.

Bright-red bows decorated trees and signposts lining the procession route along Milwaukee Avenue and Harlem Avenue, in the firefighter’s honor.

A Chicago flag covered Meyer’s wood coffin.

The 54-year-old had served as a captain of Truck 29 and spent most of his career on the West Side.

Around 4 a.m. Wednesday, Meyer responded to a garage fire in the 5500 block of West Crystal Street. The blaze was extinguished, but Meyer was

Turn to Funeral, Page 4

Head Start aiming to stop bid to ‘dismantle’

Groups file suit against Trump administration over threat to programs

By Addison Wright and Molly Morrow
Chicago Tribune

A lawsuit challenging the Trump administration’s efforts to “dismantle” Head Start programs in Illinois and across the country has been filed by the American Civil Liberties Union on behalf of Head Start groups, arguing the federal actions are unconstitutional and have left Head Start operators in a position where they “do not know whether they will suddenly be forced to close in a day, a week or a month.”

In Illinois, Head Start programs last year received over \$400 million in federal funding, supporting 28,000 low-income children and families while employing more than 9,000 Illinois residents. Along with supporting early learning, these programs provide meals, health services, support for children with disabilities and more, according to Lauri Morrison-Frichtl, executive director of the Illinois Head Start Association, a plaintiff in the lawsuit.

“This is not against any party. It’s against those that don’t have the common sense to know that this is a really important engine to drive our economy,” Morrison-Frichtl said. “Without child care, parents won’t have a place to take their child, to go to work, and it’s those kinds of points in the mission that have always, you know, that both sides of the aisle support because they realize the importance of our work.”

In addition to asking the federal court to stop the administration from stripping funding for Head Start and closing program offices, the lawsuit also challenges a mid-March executive order requiring programs to certify that they’ve removed all diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives before they can receive grant funding, calling it

Turn to Lawsuit, Page 8

INSIDE

The perks of city’s Pilsen neighborhood

One mile, more than a dozen Latino-owned cafes: How Pilsen’s coffee culture is growing across 18th Street. **Food & Health**

Bears don’t make big splash in backfield

This year’s running back class was one of deepest in recent memory, but the Bears waited until Round 7 to draft one. **Chicago Sports**



Jonah Simpson, right, 13, jumps rope alongside his brother Linus, 11, on Sunday as people enjoy the temporarily car-free space along the 4700 block of North Lincoln Avenue. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Lincoln Square weighs impact of car-free zone

Residents take advantage of extended road closure

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Rony Islam usually visits Welles Park in the morning to read a book, lie out in a hammock and enjoy a quiet moment alone. But recently, Islam has instead been going to read in the 4700 block of North Lincoln Avenue — an area typically filled with parked cars where people run

to and from stores, going about their day.

The 4700 block was supposed to be closed to vehicular access for a week to accommodate construction work on the Western Avenue Brown Line station, a nearby public plaza and a parking lot. However, a damaged brick vault found during construction

Turn to Car-free, Page 2

